



MIJBIL THE OTTER

English - Class 10 | Complete Comprehensive Study Notes

Author: Gavin Maxwell

About the Author:

Gavin Maxwell (1914–1969) was a Scottish naturalist, author, and traveller. He is best known for his books about his life with otters in the remote Scottish highlands. His most famous work is *Ring of Bright Water*, which describes his relationship with otters. Maxwell had a deep love for animals and nature. He lived a somewhat unconventional life, often in isolated places, observing and caring for wildlife. In this extract from his book, he shares his personal and humorous experiences with a pet otter named Mijbil, highlighting the joys, challenges, and deep bond between humans and animals.

1. Themes and Values

Theme:

- Human-animal relationship and companionship.
- The intelligence, curiosity, and playful nature of animals.
- Challenges of keeping a wild animal as a pet.
- Adapting to new environments and forming unexpected friendships.
- Love for nature and wildlife.

Values:

- Respect and care for animals.
- Patience and understanding while dealing with pets.
- Importance of freedom and natural habitat for wild creatures.
- Joy of companionship and unconditional love.
- Observation and learning from nature.
- Responsibility that comes with owning a pet.

2. Characters

Gavin Maxwell: Narrator and protagonist — a patient, observant, and affectionate animal lover.

Mijbil (Mij): The otter — intelligent, playful, mischievous, and affectionate. The central character of the story.

The Author's Friends and People in London: They react with surprise and curiosity to the otter.

Iraqi Officials and People: Appear briefly during the journey.

3. Summary

The story begins when Gavin Maxwell is in Basra (Iraq) and decides to bring home an otter instead of a dog as a pet. He had previously owned an otter named Chota, who had died. When he expressed his desire to his friend, the friend helped him get a new otter from the marshes near Basra. The otter was brought to him in a sack. At first, the otter was shy and frightened. Maxwell named him Mijbil (shortened to Mij).

Mijbil belonged to a species of otter that was previously unknown to science at that time. In the beginning, Mij was very aloof and did not respond to Maxwell. For the first 24 hours, he remained distant and refused to eat. Maxwell was worried. Slowly, Mij began to explore his new surroundings. He started showing his natural playful and

curious behaviour. He loved playing with water. He would jump into the bathtub and splash water all around the room with great joy. Mij invented many games with a rubber ball — he would juggle it, throw it, and catch it like an expert. He even played with broken toys and other objects in the house.

Maxwell describes Mijbil's intelligence and mischievous nature in great detail. The otter followed Maxwell everywhere like a dog. He had a strong personality and would demand attention. When Maxwell worked at his desk, Mij would sit on his knees or pull at his papers. He was full of energy and curiosity. Maxwell had to be very careful because Mij could create complete chaos in the house within minutes.

When it was time to return to England, Maxwell faced many difficulties in transporting Mij. He had to get special permission and papers from the Iraqi authorities. The journey was long and complicated. At the London airport, the otter was almost sent by cargo instead of with Maxwell. Finally, they reached home in Scotland.

In London, Mijbil became a centre of attraction. People on the street would stop and stare at the unusual animal. Maxwell took Mij for walks on a lead. The otter loved playing in the water and exploring new places. He was very friendly but also strong-willed. Maxwell narrates many humorous incidents — how Mij would escape and cause trouble, how he loved the bathroom, and how he developed his own habits and routines.

The story beautifully shows the deep bond that developed between Maxwell and Mijbil. Mij became like a family member. He brought immense joy, laughter, and life into Maxwell's home, but he also required constant care and attention. The author highlights how Mij retained his wild instincts even while living with humans. The extract ends with a sense of wonder at the intelligence and personality of this remarkable otter.

4. Moral (in points)

- Animals are intelligent and have unique personalities; we should treat them with love and respect.
- Keeping a wild animal as a pet requires great patience, responsibility, and understanding.
- Companionship with animals can bring immense joy and teach us important life lessons.
- We should appreciate and protect wildlife and their natural habitats.

- Small creatures can have big personalities and teach us about unconditional love.
- Adapting to new environments is challenging for both humans and animals.
- Observation and empathy help us build strong bonds with other living beings.
- Nature is full of surprises and wonderful creatures that enrich our lives.

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